ACADEMIC CV MASTER GUIDE

A practical guide to building an Academic CV for Master's, PhD, scholarships, fellowships, research opportunities and academic programmes.

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How to Use This Guide

This guide is designed to help you decide what belongs in an Academic CV, how to structure it, how to describe your evidence, and how to build a strong CV even when you have limited formal research experience. You do not need to use every section. Choose the sections that strengthen your application.

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1. Academic CV vs. Professional CV

An academic CV and a professional CV serve different purposes.

An academic CV presents your academic background, research experience, publications, projects, academic achievements and other evidence of your potential for further study or research.

A professional CV focuses primarily on your work experience, professional skills, responsibilities and results relevant to a specific job.

When should you use an Academic CV?

- Master’s applications
- PhD applications
- Academic scholarships
- Research assistant positions
- Research opportunities
- Fellowships
- Academic programmes
- Graduate funding opportunities

When should you use a Professional CV?

- Corporate and private-sector jobs
- Professional roles
- Recruitment applications
- Business opportunities
- Industry positions

What goes into an Academic CV?

- Academic Profile / Research Interests
- Education
- Research Experience
- Publications
- Research & Academic Projects
- Work Experience
- Internships
- Conferences & Presentations
- Awards & Scholarships
- Leadership & Volunteering
- Certifications / Relevant Courses
- IELTS / TOEFL
- GRE, where relevant
- Media / Academic Outreach

- Online Portfolio

You do not need to have every section. Your CV should reflect your actual experience and prioritise the areas that strengthen your application.

An Academic CV Is Not Just a Longer CV

An academic CV is not simply a professional CV with more information added to it. The content, emphasis and order should change according to the purpose of the application.

> **Professional CV:** Marketing Intern — XYZ Ltd
> Managed social media content and supported digital campaigns.
>
> **Academic CV:** Marketing Research Intern — XYZ Ltd
> Conducted competitor and consumer research across three market segments and contributed findings to the development of a digital marketing strategy.

The second example brings attention to research, analysis and contribution, which may be more relevant when presenting an academic profile.

You Don’t Need to Make Your CV Look “Academic”

Your academic CV does not need to be filled with publications, conferences and research positions. If you have relevant work experience, internships, leadership, volunteering, projects or professional achievements, include them.

The goal is not to make your CV look artificially academic. The goal is to present the strongest evidence of your preparation, ability and potential for the opportunity you are applying for.

> **The simplest way to think about it:**
> Professional CV: What can you do, and what have you achieved professionally?
> Academic CV: What have you studied, researched, produced and achieved, and how does this demonstrate your potential for further study or research?

Your academic CV should give the reader a clear understanding of where you are academically, what you have done, what you are interested in, and where you are going.

2. What Makes an Academic CV Strong

A strong academic CV is not about having the most sections, the longest list of certificates or the highest number of pages. It should give the reader a clear picture of your academic background, preparation, achievements, interests and potential.

1. A Clear Academic Direction

What you studied; what areas you are interested in; what you have worked on; what you want to study or research next. Experiences do not need to follow a perfectly straight path, but the connection between your background and intended programme should be understandable.

2. Evidence, Not Claims

Don’t simply describe yourself as research-oriented, analytical, passionate, a strong leader, or interested in a particular field. Show evidence. Weak: “Passionate about public health research.” Strong: “Conducted an independent study examining barriers to healthcare access among 300 low-income households.” Experiences should demonstrate qualities.

3. Evidence of Preparation

Preparation can come from research projects, undergraduate dissertations, relevant coursework, internships, work experience, academic projects, research assistantships, technical projects, conferences and relevant training. Ask: What have you done that demonstrates your readiness for this programme?

4. Specificity

Weak: “Worked on research and assisted with data analysis.” Stronger: “Analysed survey data from 450 respondents using SPSS and contributed to the preparation of the final research report.” The second example tells what, scale and tool.

5. Achievements & Outputs

Show what work produced: publications, research findings, completed projects, conference presentations, scholarships, awards, competition results, reports, policy recommendations and tools/products developed.

6. Relevance Over Volume

Five relevant courses > 25 unrelated certificates. Two substantial research projects > 10 barely explained. One meaningful leadership position > long list of memberships. Prioritise academic preparation and potential.

7. Tailor Your CV to the Programme

Core experience can remain the same, but emphasis and order can change. Data Science: statistics, programming, data projects, quantitative research. International Development: development research, economics, public policy, fieldwork, community projects, social impact.

8. Accuracy & Academic Credibility

Be accurate/verifiable about degrees/classifications, publication status, research contribution, conference participation, awards, test scores, certifications, research methods/tools, dates and positions. Do not call an under-review manuscript published; do not call yourself lead researcher if you supported. Accuracy > appearance.

3. The Structure of a Strong Academic CV

There is no single structure every academic CV must follow. Organise around your strongest and most relevant evidence.

Core Sections

- Name & Contact Information
- Academic Profile / Research Interests
- Education
- Research Experience
- Publications
- Research & Academic Projects
- Work Experience
- Internships
- Conferences & Presentations
- Awards & Scholarships
- Leadership & Volunteering
- Technical / Research Skills

Supporting Sections

- Certifications / Relevant Courses
- IELTS / TOEFL
- GRE
- Languages
- Media / Academic Outreach
- Online Portfolio / Academic Profiles

You do not need all sections. Supporting examples: IELTS/TOEFL when required or useful; GRE when required or relevant; Languages when relevant to programme/research/location; Media/Academic Outreach when relevant; Online Portfolio for GitHub, research portfolio, website, Google Scholar, etc.

Examples

- Undergraduate with limited research: Education → Research & Academic Projects → Internships → Work Experience → Skills → Awards
- Research-focused master's: Academic Profile → Education → Research Experience → Publications → Research Projects → Skills
- PhD: Research Experience → Publications → Teaching Experience → Grants/Funding → Conferences → Academic Service

> The structure should serve your profile—not the other way around.

4. How to Order Your Academic CV

No single order works for every CV. It depends on your academic level, field, experience and the requirements of the opportunity. General rule: put your strongest and most relevant evidence early.

Starting Structure

- Academic Profile / Research Interests — optional
- Education
- Research Experience
- Publications
- Research & Academic Projects
- Work Experience
- Internships
- Teaching Experience — where relevant
- Conferences & Presentations
- Awards & Scholarships
- Leadership & Volunteering
- Technical / Research Skills
- Certifications / Relevant Courses
- IELTS / TOEFL / GRE — where relevant
- Languages
- Media / Academic Outreach
- Online Portfolio / Academic Profiles

This is not a rule.

Change the Order Based on Your Evidence

- Research strongest → research/publications/projects/skills after education
- Relevant professional experience → Work Experience higher
- Strong projects, little formal research → projects after education
- Technical programme → technical/research skills, projects, methods/tools
- PhD/research-intensive → research, publications, conferences, teaching, academic work

When Two Sections Compete

- Which is more relevant to the programme?
- Which demonstrates academic preparation or research potential?
- Does it contain enough substance to deserve prominence?
- Is there stronger evidence elsewhere?

Unrelated extensive work can go lower; a directly relevant internship can outrank unrelated years of work.

Let the Opportunity Guide the Order

- Research → Research Experience / Publications / Projects / Skills

- Academic achievement → Education / Awards / Scholarships / Projects
- Technical → Technical Skills / Research Methods / Programming / Projects
- Professional → Relevant Work / Internships
- Teaching → Teaching / Tutoring / Academic Support
- Language → relevant qualifications/test scores

> The goal is not to rearrange every application from scratch. It is to give the most relevant evidence appropriate prominence.

5. How to Write Your Academic Profile / Research Interests

This section gives the reader a quick understanding of your academic background, focus, relevant experience and intended direction. It usually sits near the top and can combine your profile and research interests.

What to Include

- Current academic/professional background
- Field or area
- Relevant research experience or academic work
- Specific areas you want to explore
- Intended academic direction

Weak Example

> “I am a hardworking and passionate graduate with a strong interest in public health. I am passionate about research and hope to contribute to the field through further studies.”
>
> Problem: little actual background, experience or direction.

Stronger Example

> “Public Health graduate with research experience in maternal and child health, including a study examining healthcare access and health-seeking behaviour in underserved communities.”

Make Research Interests Specific

Avoid broad statements such as “Interested in technology,” “Interested in healthcare,” “Interested in AI,” or “Interested in international development.” Narrow them to themes, problems, populations, methods or emerging areas.

> Example: “Research interests include natural language processing, responsible AI and the application of machine learning to healthcare.”

Interests should connect to your background, work or programme, but they do not need to be perfectly defined early in your career.

Possible Research Interest Areas

- Research field
- Problem or issue
- Population or setting
- Theme
- Methodology
- Emerging area

> Example: “Financial inclusion, digital financial services and access to credit among small businesses in emerging markets.”

Keep the profile to roughly 2–4 sentences. It is not a personal statement, biography, soft-skill list, whole-CV summary or long “why this programme” paragraph.

Research Interests may be more useful for research-focused master's/PhD applications, research assistant roles and fellowships. You can use bullets such as AI in healthcare; NLP; clinical decision-support; responsible/explainable AI.

You can omit this section if it adds no value or simply repeats the rest of the CV. Tailor naturally to the opportunity; do not copy the programme description or keyword-stuff.

Avoid

- Age, marital status, religion or irrelevant personal information
- Generic objectives
- Long personal stories
- Unsupported personality claims
- Broad interests with no evidence

> Key principle: describe academic direction with specific evidence rather than "hardworking, passionate, motivated, results-driven."

6. How to Write the Education Section

The Education section shows your academic background and qualifications and is usually near the top of an Academic CV.

Include

- Degree/qualification
- Institution
- City/country if included
- Dates attended or expected/graduation date
- GPA/CGPA/classification when relevant
- Thesis/dissertation/major research project when relevant
- Relevant coursework when useful
- Academic honours/distinctions

Example
BSc. Biochemistry
University of Lagos, Lagos, Nigeria | 2022–2026
CGPA: 4.42/5.00
Dissertation: Investigating the Antimicrobial Properties of Selected Plant Extracts Against Bacterial Pathogens

Use reverse chronological order.

Usually, do not include primary school. Secondary school may be included for an undergraduate with limited academic history, a notable achievement, or where specifically requested.

Include GPA/CGPA/classification if it strengthens the application or is required. Class rank/distinction can be included when relevant. Do not convert a GPA unless requested or there is a reliable basis for doing so.

Relevant coursework can demonstrate preparation, especially when experience is limited. Examples: Statistics, Econometrics, Financial Economics, Research Methods. Do not list every course.

A thesis, dissertation or major project title can sit under the degree; detailed methodology and findings can go under Research Experience or Research & Academic Projects.

Key principle: show what you studied, where, when, and the academic details that strengthen the application—not every possible detail.

7. How to Write the Research Experience Section

Research Experience shows experience investigating questions, collecting or analysing information, applying methods, or contributing to research. You do not need a university title or a formal “Research Assistant” position.

Research Experience Can Come From

- Research assistantships
- Undergraduate/master’s dissertations
- Independent research
- Faculty/university projects
- Research internships
- Field research
- Research in employment
- Laboratory work
- Research-based academic projects

Research Experience vs. Academic Projects

Research Experience usually involves structured research with a supervisor, team or institution. Research & Academic Projects can include coursework, independent projects, dissertations, technical projects and other substantial academic work. Use the most accurate label; do not invent a title.

An independent project should not be called Research Assistant simply to make it sound stronger.

Include

- Role/project title
- Institution/organisation
- Location
- Dates
- Topic
- Specific contribution
- Methods/tools
- Outputs/findings

Useful formula: What you worked on → How you approached it → Your contribution → Output/result

Example
Research Assistant — University of Lagos | Jan 2025–Aug 2025
• Collected and cleaned survey data from 450 respondents on healthcare access.
• Analysed quantitative data using SPSS and contributed to interpretation.
• Assisted with the research report and presentation.

Methods & Tools You Can Show

- SPSS, R, Python, Stata, NVivo, MATLAB, Excel
- Statistical analysis
- Interviews

- Survey design/data collection
- Literature reviews
- Laboratory techniques
- Fieldwork
- Experiments

Only include numbers you can support.

If you have no formal research experience, use dissertations, major research projects, independent research, substantial coursework, research internships and field/lab work. Research & Academic Projects may be more prominent than Research Experience.

> Key principle: the title matters less than what you investigated, what you did, how you did it, your contribution and the output.

8. How to Write Publications & Research / Academic Projects

Publications and substantial academic projects demonstrate your ability to investigate questions, apply methods, analyse evidence and produce academic work. You do not need publications for a strong Academic CV, especially as an undergraduate or early-career applicant.

Publications

Include authors, title, journal/conference/outlet, year and DOI or link where applicable.

> Okafor, C. & Bello, T. (2026). Digital financial inclusion among small businesses in emerging markets. Journal of Financial Research, 12(2), 45–61. DOI/link.

Accurately distinguish publication status: Published; Accepted/Forthcoming; Under Review; In Preparation. Keep author order accurate.

Unpublished research can go under Research & Academic Projects or Research Papers/Manuscripts. Do not place it under Publications or imply that it has been accepted.

Research & Academic Projects Can Include

- Undergraduate dissertations
- Master's theses
- Independent research
- Major coursework
- Laboratory projects
- Data analysis projects
- Technical/computational projects
- Policy research
- Field studies
- Research conducted during internships or employment

For Each Project, Include

- Title
- Institution/programme
- Date
- What you investigated or your involvement
- Methods/tools
- Output/result

> **Example**
> **The Impact of Digital Financial Services on Small Businesses — University of Lagos | 2025**
> • Examined digital payment platforms and financial access.
> • Analysed 300 survey responses using SPSS.
> • Identified adoption barriers and presented findings.

Prioritise relevant and substantial projects, research/analytical/technical skills and outputs.

No publications? Fine. Do not create a Publications section just because you think an Academic CV must have one. A few relevant, substantive pieces are better than a long unexplained list.

9. How to Write Work Experience & Internships

Work experience and internships can strengthen an Academic CV when they demonstrate relevant knowledge, skills, research exposure or preparation. An Academic CV is not limited to university or research positions.

Include

- Job title
- Organisation
- Location
- Dates
- Relevant responsibilities, contributions and achievements

Focus on Relevance

- Subject-matter knowledge
- Research or analytical ability
- Technical skills
- Relevant professional experience
- Communication/academic skills
- Leadership or project responsibility

Describe Contributions, Not Just Duties

> **Duty:** “Responsible for data entry and administrative duties.”
>
> **Better:** “Entered and verified survey responses from 600 participants and maintained the research dataset using Excel.”

Show outcomes or scale where useful, but do not invent numbers. Show promotions or increased responsibility using your actual titles.

Internships count, including short or unpaid internships, when they are substantial and relevant. Freelance, contract and part-time work can also be included when relevant.

Where Work Experience Appears

- Research-focused: Education → Research → Publications → Projects → Relevant Work
- Professionally oriented master’s: Education → Relevant Work → Research/Academic Projects → Other Experience

Unrelated jobs can remain if they explain your background or demonstrate useful transferable skills, but they should not receive excessive space.

Keep dates and titles accurate. Do not make a role sound more academic or senior than it was.

> Key principle: show what you know, what you can do, and how your experience prepares you for the academic opportunity.

10. Teaching, Conferences, Awards, Leadership, Volunteering & Academic Service

These sections are optional. Use them when they provide evidence of academic engagement, achievement, leadership, communication or contribution.

Teaching Experience

Include teaching assistantships, graduate teaching, tutoring, peer teaching, academic mentoring, lab instruction and workshops. Include role, institution, subject/course, dates and what you taught or supported.

Conferences & Presentations

Include conference presentations, research posters, academic seminars, panel presentations, invited talks and relevant workshops. Attendance alone is usually not prominent unless it was selective or otherwise meaningful.

Awards, Scholarships & Fellowships

Include academic awards, scholarships, fellowships, research grants, competition awards, Dean’s/departmental awards and merit recognition. Include name, organisation and year; note competitiveness when accurate.

Leadership & Volunteering

Student leadership, professional associations, community projects, nonprofit volunteering, academic societies, committees, mentoring and outreach can be useful. Focus on your actual contribution, not simply membership.

Academic Service

Examples include peer reviewing, journal/editorial assistance, conference organising, academic society committees, departmental committees and research/academic event coordination.

> Leave out low-value or unrelated attendance and memberships. These sections should support your profile, not fill space.

11. How to Write Skills, Certifications & Test Scores

These sections provide additional evidence of preparation, technical ability and qualifications. Avoid turning your CV into a keyword dump.

Technical & Research Skills

- Research Methods: survey design, qualitative interviews, literature review, statistical analysis
- Software: SPSS, R, Excel, NVivo
- Programming: Python, SQL
- Technical: GIS, laboratory techniques, data visualisation

Avoid listing skills you have barely used. Ideally, demonstrate the skill elsewhere through research, projects, work or coursework.

Skill levels are optional and can be subjective. Demonstrated ability is usually stronger evidence than labels such as “expert.”

Certifications & Relevant Courses

Include professional qualifications, research methods training, technical certifications, relevant academic courses and industry-recognised training. Distinguish substantial or recognised training from short, low-value online courses.

IELTS / TOEFL

Include these when relevant to the application. Example: IELTS Academic — Overall 8.0 | 2026. Include individual bands if required or if they strengthen the application. Check each programme’s score requirements and validity rules.

GRE & Other Tests

Include GRE or another test when required, recommended or genuinely relevant. Omit it when it is not required and the score does not strengthen your application.

Avoid Generic Skills

- Hardworking
- Team player
- Excellent communication
- Leadership
- Microsoft Word
- Time management

Simple template
Technical & Research Skills
Research methods, software, programming, laboratory/technical methods

Certifications & Relevant Courses
Qualification — Issuing organisation — Year

Test Scores
IELTS/TOEFL/GRE — Score — Year

Key principle: skills and qualifications should support evidence shown elsewhere in the CV.

12. How to Include Languages, Academic Presence & Online Profiles

These are supporting sections. Include them when they add evidence or useful context.

Languages

List relevant languages and use a recognised level such as CEFR where applicable. Example: English — Native; French — B2; German — A2. Keep claims accurate. Formal language test scores should be listed separately when relevant.

Academic Profiles

- ORCID
- Google Scholar
- ResearchGate
- Institutional profile
- Personal academic website
- GitHub

ORCID is a persistent researcher identifier. Keep publication and research records accurate and consistent across platforms.

Academic Website / Online Portfolio

A useful site can contain your CV, research interests, publications, projects, presentations, bio and contact details. A portfolio can also show research projects, posters, data projects, software/code and writing samples.

Make sure every link works and does not require the reader to request access. Do not link private documents.

Academic Outreach

This can include public lectures, educational content, science communication, podcasts, research outreach, community education and articles explaining academic topics. You do not need a formal title to include meaningful outreach.

Ordinary social accounts should only be included when relevant to the academic or professional profile.

> Key principle: supporting sections should add evidence or context—not simply add length.

13. How to Build an Academic CV With Limited Experience

You do not need publications, research assistantships or years of professional experience to build a credible Academic CV. The goal is to identify your strongest evidence and present it clearly.

Start With What You Have

- Education
- Dissertation/thesis
- Academic projects
- Research assignments
- Relevant coursework
- Internships
- Work experience
- Laboratory/fieldwork
- Teaching/tutoring
- Conferences/presentations
- Awards/scholarships
- Leadership
- Volunteering
- Technical/research skills
- Relevant certifications

Use Academic Projects Properly

If you have no formal research experience, substantial projects can demonstrate research ability. Instead of writing only “Final Year Project,” use a descriptive title such as “Research Project: Factors Influencing Access to Healthcare Among Rural Communities,” then explain what you investigated, your approach and the output.

Relevant Coursework Can Help

Coursework is particularly useful when experience is limited and the courses demonstrate preparation for the programme.

Internships and Other Experience Count

Relevant internships, part-time work, freelance work, volunteering and professional experience can all demonstrate preparation when described accurately.

Do Not Manufacture Experience

Do not invent research positions, publications, leadership roles or achievements. A smaller CV with credible evidence is stronger than an impressive-looking CV built on inflated claims.

Let Education Do More Work

- Degree
- Institution
- Academic performance

- Thesis/dissertation
- Relevant coursework
- Honours/distinctions
- Academic projects

Build Evidence Before Application Season

- Take on substantial research projects
- Seek faculty or institutional research opportunities
- Build technical projects
- Present academic work
- Publish where appropriate
- Participate in competitions or academic programmes
- Develop relevant research/technical skills
- Keep accurate records of your achievements

Suggested Structure

- Academic Profile / Research Interests
- Education
- Research / Academic Projects
- Research Experience if applicable
- Relevant Work / Internships
- Awards & Scholarships
- Leadership / Volunteering
- Technical & Research Skills
- Certifications / Relevant Courses
- Languages / Academic Profiles where relevant

Key principle: limited experience does not mean you have nothing to show. Present your strongest evidence rather than trying to manufacture a more “academic” profile.

14. Final Academic CV Checklist

Before submitting your Academic CV, check each of the following:

- Your name and contact information are correct.
- Your email address is professional and active.
- The CV is tailored to the programme, scholarship, fellowship or research opportunity.
- The strongest and most relevant evidence appears early.
- Your Education section is accurate and complete.
- Research experience and projects clearly explain your contribution.
- Publication status is completely accurate.
- You have not presented under-review or in-preparation work as published.
- Dates, job titles, degree details and institutions are consistent.
- Methods, tools and technical skills are supported by actual experience.
- Awards, scholarships and test scores are accurate.
- Unrelated information has been removed or reduced.
- Links to portfolios, publications and profiles work.
- There are no unnecessary personal details.
- The document is easy to scan and professionally formatted.
- Spelling, grammar and formatting have been checked.
- The final version is saved with a professional filename, e.g. Firstname_Lastname_Academic_CV.pdf.

Final question: If an admissions committee, scholarship reviewer or researcher spent 30–60 seconds scanning your CV, would they immediately understand what you studied, what you have done, what you are capable of, and what you want to pursue next?